

PHRASING IS KING

FROM DIGGING DEEPER VIDEO #179

Cool licks and hip harmonic devices are what many of us get excited about learning, but working on our PHRASING can change our sound and conception quicker, and often more dramatically. For those of us still getting our improvisation skills together, straightening out our phrasing is a very important place to invest some time. For the pros, our phrasing and phrase lengths are a huge aspect of what give us our personal sound. Let's dig in to it.

#1 - Phrasing in two measure phrases

Exercise #1: Phrasing in two measure phrases. The exercise is written in 4/4 time and consists of three staves, each with four measures. The first staff has chords $Bb7$, $Eb7$, and $Bb7$. The second staff has chords $Eb7$, $Bb7$, and $G7$. The third staff has chords $Cm7$, $F7$, $Bb7$, and $F7$. Each measure contains a single eighth note, and the notes are beamed across the two-measure phrases.

#2 - Phrasing in four measure phrases

Exercise #2: Phrasing in four measure phrases. The exercise is written in 4/4 time and consists of three staves, each with four measures. The first staff has chords $Bb7$, $Eb7$, and $Bb7$. The second staff has chords $Eb7$, $Bb7$, and $G7$. The third staff has chords $Cm7$, $F7$, $Bb7$, and $F7$. Each measure contains a single eighth note, and the notes are beamed across the four-measure phrases.

Once we have good control over our two and four measure phrases, it is fun to begin experimenting with different phrase lengths. Mix them up, play dramatically longer and shorter phrases, be a bit more organic with them. This is referred to as "playing over the barline." This can give us a more modern feel, and makes our playing less predictable.

#3 - Phrasing in random phrase lengths

The image shows four staves of musical notation, each with four measures. The notation is simplified, using slurs and accidentals to represent chords and phrase lengths. The chords are as follows:

- Staff 1: $Bb7$ (measures 1-2), $Eb7$ (measures 3-4), $Bb7$ (measures 5-6), $Bb7$ (measures 7-8).
- Staff 2: $Eb7$ (measures 1-2), $Bb7$ (measures 3-4), $G7$ (measures 5-6), $G7$ (measures 7-8).
- Staff 3: $Cm7$ (measures 1-2), $F7$ (measures 3-4), $Bb7$ (measures 5-6), $F7$ (measures 7-8).
- Staff 4: $Bb7$ (measures 1-2), $Eb7$ (measures 3-4), $Bb7$ (measures 5-6), $Bb7$ (measures 7-8).

etc